

MEQ PRACTICE QUESTIONS (CASE STUDIES)

MODIFIED ESSAY QUESTION 10

You are a junior psychiatrist and Virginia is a 14 yr old girl who has been referred to your community mental health service by her family doctor who has diagnosed her as having chronic fatigue syndrome. Virginia has a two-year history of excessive tiredness and nonspecific physical symptoms. Virginia has had home schooling for the past year, avoids social settings and has a little contact with peers. She says she could do all things “if they were open at night when I am awake”. She stays up watching television and talking to online internet chat rooms until 3 am and then sleeps until midday. Virginia’s mother, Mrs Bennett, has stopped work so she can care for her daughter. The family doctor says she has excluded all significant organic issues of Virginia’s fatigue but wonders if there are psychiatric problems. She requests that you assess and treat her. You take her history and carry out her mental state examination.

- a) Outline the areas of history that you would focus on in assessing her presentation. (15 marks)**
- b) Outline differential diagnosis you would consider.**

Mother asked for a sleeping tablet.

- c) Outline your advice.**

MODIFIED ESSAY QUESTION 11

A 67 year old lady with recurrent treatment resistant depressive disorder, presents with severe depressive episode of two months duration. She has developed nihilistic delusions and is very agitated over the last two weeks. She has been on Escitalopram 20 mg per day for the last two years. Husband and daughter are aware she is fearful of and has previously been adamant in her refusal of ECT. Her brother died of suicide aged, 20, after having ECT for depression. Her husband and daughter feel ECT is not appropriate and objects strongly to this treatment. On the inpatient unit, she is initially commenced on venlafaxine, which was titrated to 225 mg mane over a period of three weeks with no effect. Subsequently, she was crossed titrated with nortriptyline with a dose of 100 mg being maintained over a two-week period along with a mood stabiliser.

- a) Outline the professional and ethical issues raised by this scenario.**
- b) Outline the factors that could be contributing to her depression failing to improve**
- c) Outline the factors that may be contributing to family’s opposition to ECT**

After a lengthy discussion with the patient and her family, the plan is made to begin a course of right unilateral ECT while optimising the dose of nortriptyline to 150mg daily. By the sixth treatment, however, some signs of hypomania are evident.

d) Describe the management you will recommend. Outline the possible treatment options at this point.